

publications for company, the WPL accords drew questions every day from the e-rickshaw or cab drivers ferrying us to the ground at the Feroz Shah Kotla premises, with many thinking it was preparations for the Indian Premier League (IPL) that were drawing crowds to the venue.

The diary decided to step into the daunting world of shopping in Delhi's famous markets with a first pitstop at Janpath. Despite having a Delhi native along (for moral support and protection from being fleeced), shopkeepers had a knack for targeting the diary with higher prices, like they could sniff the non-Delhiite around them.

The hour before a game was spent getting to know some of the fans. Many had only ever heard of Smriti Mandhana. There were big Ellyse Perry fans and the odd Harmanpreet Kaur, Shafali Verma, and Jemimah Rodrigues admirers as well. However, when quizzed about who the five-time World Cup-winning captain (Meg Lanning, skipper of Delhi Capitals) participating in the tournament was, nine out of 10 wore puzzled looks.

And so it was particularly delightful to run into Sneh Rishav, a student from Delhi School of Journalism, who turned out to be a Lanning encyclopaedia, rattling out stats and milestones from her career like a town crier announcing the impending arrival of royalty. There was even a time when retired South African cricketer

Dane van Niekerk, supporting her wife



Fuelling fervour of WPL: Meera Didi, vending jerseys for 25 years at India matches, now avidly follows women's cricket. Meanwhile, the world heritage site of Qutb Minar was lit up with the faces of Royal Challengers Bangalore and Delhi Capitals captains ahead of the WPL final. LAVANYA LAKSHMI NARAYANAN

Marizanne Kapp in Delhi Capitals, walked through the busy peripheries of the Kotla largely unrecognised.

During the Delhi leg, the diary noticed knock-off jersey sellers near the stadium, including Meera Didi, who's attended India matches for 25 years, favouring women's cricket recently. She shares a guesthouse with other vendors, paying Rs. 800 in rent. Meera can't read or write, so she relies on journalists for player names. Only three hawkers, including Meera, had women's names on jerseys (Smriti, Jemimah, and Harmanpreet), all selling out during the first two days in Bengaluru.

After a few days, the police cleared the roads to allow an easier flow of people through the narrow lane around the stadium, leaving these sellers with no place to go. The case was the same for a few face painters, who were not allowed to settle near the gate entrances. One of them even decided not to return, declaring it was just easier to return for the IPL when such restrictions wouldn't be in place.

Another mandatory pre-match ritual was a verbal tussle with the police stationed outside the stadium. Accreditation cards did not suffice to convince them that the diary was a member of the press. "Do press

wale andar chale gaye. Aap kaise keh rahe ho ki aap press ho? (Two members of the press are already in. How

are you claiming to be from the media?)" and "You can get in, sure. But no laptop," were some of the responses

